# Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

## Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

Honestly, I use food stamps. I buy my things. I go buy when I get my food stamps. I will look if anyone can help me with transportation. I can not always go get all my things by car so I am forced to get all the things I need until I run out of food stamps at one go. When the amount of food stamps I have finishes, I divide the food I do have to make sure it does last me the month but honestly this past month, I was very limited in what I could do. It wasn't enough because the oil here is expensive, ghee is expensive, meat is expensive especially since we have to get halal. As much as I can, I try to make the food we get from wic last. The last two days the food we have eaten has come from my husbands income.

FQ: When you got food on food stamps the first 3 months before your husbands employment, was it enough for your household?

Honestly it was. But when my husband started working and they started lessening our food stamp amount, that's when we broke. We were not able to keep up with the demand of food in our household. We could not get enough food for month. We tried to adjust to the new situation but it would not work out for us. But when we had it every month, we were able to try and survive. But they cut it off for two months, imagine how that was. We went and try to get our case open again and they told us we had to go and open our case again on our own. We had to give them new paper work for when my husband started working. We did not know any of this information. By the time we were giving them our paper work and working on our case,they had cut us off of food stamps for two months. In those two months, only god knows what happened. I had to ask my daughter for help.

FQ: do you have pots and pans?

IRC gave us pots and pans but I brought some too. I use the ones I got more because they did gives us pots and pans but they aren't enough for us.

FQ: What did you bring with you when you moved to the states from Jordan?

I brought pots and pans. I got coffee pots, tea pots, cups, dishes, utensils, and knives. I brought the things I use the most with me.

FQ: where do you get your groceries from?

Anywhere cheap we go to it. We get from Walmart, Shahrazad, smiths I've been there once. Rancho I go there the most, its also the cheapest. The vegetables they sell are acceptable in my opinion.

FQ: do you go to any Arabic markets?

Of course. Shahrazad only.

FQ: do you know how to cook?

Yes, I know how to cook and love to cook.

Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:

b. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

Like I told you they did not get food stamps for two months. Those two months until the end of the second month, we had no food. It was a very hard two months. We had no money, I had to ask my daughter for help. If my daughter wasn't here I wouldn't have gone and looked for help from anyone else. First of all, I do not know how to speak English which would make it so much more difficult. So if I didn't have my daughter I would have not gotten help.

FQ: did IRC help you?

Honestly they did not help me. Our caseworker gets changed every 3 months. As soon as our almost situation gets settled by the caseworker, they change them. And I am the type not to talk to them. But I told them that they made my husband work and then you cut off our food stamps. They told us that we have to go to DWS and file new paper work but they did not tell us that at the moment that he got employed. We had no idea. They told us we had to go fix it ourselves when it was cut off but they didn't tell us before hand. We waited the first month and did no get food stamps. The second month they told us my husband started working. I told them you are the ones who got my husband a job so you are supposed to know and update the paperwork.

FQ: do you have a computer at home?

No

FQ: The caseworker applied for food stamps for you?

Yes

FQ: how did you get food stamps back?

I had to go to IRC then DWS to give them the paper work. We had to prove that my oldest son studies and he doesn't work. Then after we gave them everything, they gave us food stamps back. But they warned us if my son started working we have to go back and file the paperwork. They told us what I need to do when he starts working.

FQ: is the amount you get in food stamps after your husbands employment enough for you?

Honestly, I try to make it work as much as possible.

i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

c. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

From my daughter. I had to ask my daughter's friend for help. IRC told me I had to get paperwork to prove my son was in school and proof of how much my husband made. It took us two months to figure it out. If I did not do all these things we would have stayed 3 – 4 months without food stamps.

FQ: you told me you have a language barrier, are you provided with a translator?

Yes. If they didn't I would have used google translate. I use that a lot when I do not have a translator.

d. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

IRC helped us get food stamps only. They did not show us where we can buy food. My daughter showed me where I can buy foods.

FQ: How long has she been in Utah?

A year (So she has been there for 8 months more than you?) yes

FQ: Do you use food from a food pantry or farmers market?

No let me tell you why. I do not know of any and I have no way of getting there. I don't have a UTA pass. I don't have the privilege of being able to go and seeing if they have food I can eat.

FQ: so you have no way of getting to places?

No

FQ: how do you get to places?

I usually take the bus. I take my daughters stroller. I put everything in the stroller and then have to push it to the bus stop then have to pick it up and put it on the bus. There are a lot of hardships when it comes to this.\

FQ: do you buy to take the bus?

Yes.

FQ: how long does it take you to get groceries and come home?

I have to take two buses there and two buses back. So it takes me about 4 hours to get groceries and come home. The wait for the bus takes the longest. (do you try to get everything all at once?) Yeah because I can't go every day. I have a little daughter and I am just not able to go to the grocery store a lot.

FQ: do you take her with you?

Some days I take her with me and others I ask her older brother to babysit her.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

IRC helped the most with food stamps. I do not have money to buy food. They just helped us get on our two feet.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Hopefully. But it is going to be trials.

FQ: if your caseworker was not able to apply for food stamps for you, would you be able to do it yourself?

No honestly

iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

e. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?

f. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:

SNAP

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

I got a promotional text on my phone and went to IRC and told them. I think the text was from IRC. When I went to tell them my situation when we first moved here they may have sent the text.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

It was a good experience. The only difficult thing is transportation.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

Everything, with food stamps? Everything. Oil, ghee, sugar, lentil, bulgur, rice, vegetables, fruits, what else? Salt. Everything you can think of.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

80%

WIC

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

IRC. They applied for me. I just gave them my information.

FQ: was there a translator?

Yes

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

Also good.

FQ: I know there are certain items you can get with WIC, did you have trouble adjusting?

Honestly my daughter was here before me. So I talked to her about my worries and by the third time I went to the store I knew how to use it.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

Milk, fruits, vegetables, pasta, things like that.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

10%

School lunch program

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

I forgot to ask. I'm sorry.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

Good, this is a good move on their part. If I was not able to make them lunch boxes, I knew they would have food to eat at school.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

Sometimes they would bring food home. Bananas, apples, milk, yogurt. But it's not a lot.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

No answer

FQ: how does your daughter help you?

Her family is small. She would help me because she would have some money on her food stamps that she would let me use. It was only for a certain amount of time. She helps me when I ask and need help. If they did not cut off the food stamps I would have been able to get food for two months. But because they cut them off for two months. I had to ask my daughter for help.

Repeat i-iv for other programs they have used.

2. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

    Very important. Everything is good but we need to hold onto our culture.

    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

    From food stamps. Rancho because it is the cheapest. Sharazad for coffee. Everything else from rancho I can find it.

    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

    They did not help me.

        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

    d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

    No

    e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

    No

## Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

They are not used to them. We are a coward people that do not like asking for food. Those who are full in their home wont be full in anothers is a saying we have. We are not used to asking for help. Our personalities don't allow us to prove that we are hungry or that we are in need of food.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

IRC has to communicate with others that there are places for them to get food. More promotions to help those who need it. Just making sure that information reaches the people that need it.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

They have to know who needs help to make sure that food is too much, not too little. Communication is key. IRC has to be able to provide support so a person does not reach the hopeless need for food.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   I would love if they increased the food stamps just until we truly have our feet on the ground. Just to grow a foundation for the first year or two.